with contracts like these. It is estimated that less than a third returned. Many perished during the sea journeys and the years of hard labour. Yet, enough of them survived to form the Indian communities scattered across these faraway lands.

Soon, Indian traders and clerks also began to follow the British to the colonies. Gujarati merchants and shopkeepers established a network in eastern and southern Africa. The Tamil Chettiar community was especially active in South East Asia and established a network in Burma, Malaya, Singapore and even French-controlled Vietnam. As they settled in these areas, they would have found tiny remnants of Indian merchant communities that had survived from ancient times. The ‘Chitty’ community, for instance, had survived for centuries in Malaya with little contact with the original homeland. They had intermarried with local women and adopted local dress, but somehow had retained their Hindu religion and customs. The community is now rapidly merging with the broader Tamil community in modern Malaysia.

Although this network of Indian communities was created and maintained by British power, the diaspora played an important role in India’s struggle for independence from colonial rule. Mahatma Gandhi, for instance, was part of the Indian community in South Africa between 1893 and 1914, and he developed his political and spiritual philosophy of non-violence while fighting for the rights of Indians there. The incident in June 1893 that changed the course of his life was his eviction, on racial grounds, from the first-class compartment of a train, despite the fact that he had a valid ticket. This took place at Pietermaritzburg station—visitors will see a plaque on the platform marking the spot where he was thrown out. Gandhi would return to India only in 1915, at the age of 46, but would soon become the country’s leading political figure.

Singapore, by contrast, was the hub of a very different effort to rid India of its colonial masters. When the Japanese captured the island-city during the Second World War, Netaji Subhash Bose used the opportunity to form the Azad Hind Fauj or Indian National Army, by recruiting Indian civilians and soldiers held as prisoners-of-war. The first review of the troops took